Right-Size Your Structure

How much structure a project needs as it grows from one team to many: just enough to stay safe, no more.

Run a Project · Inspired by Brooks's law (Fred Brooks), Scrum's small teams, SAFe's release trains and Team Topologies

PROJECT _____

DATE _____

1 One Team — LEVEL 1

3–10 people · 1 team

4 people: 6 links

PLANNING

A short planning conversation each iteration, and a simple roadmap.

Sprint Planning · Prioritisation Board

ROLES

A product owner or lead sets priorities; the team shares the rest.

Team Charter

EVENTS

Daily sync, planning, review and retro, kept short.

Events & Cadences

TRACKING WORK

One visible board. Conversation fills the gaps.

Kanban Board Design

RISKS & DEPENDENCIES

Raise them in the daily sync and planning; note the big ones.

Pre-mortem

REPORTING

Show working software at the review, plus a short note to the sponsor.

Sprint Review

DECISIONS & GOVERNANCE

Decide in the room. Write down only what people will ask about later.

Team Charter (How We Decide)

2 Team of Teams — LEVEL 2

10–50 people · 2–5 teams

40 people: 780 links

PLANNING

Plan together each planning period, with shared objectives.

Cross-Team Planning · OKRs

ROLES

Add a programme manager or RTE to coordinate, and one product lead across teams.

RACI & Decision Log

EVENTS

Add a weekly cross-team sync, a joint demo and a joint retro.

Cross-Team Sync · Cross-Team Retro

TRACKING WORK

A shared view of features across teams; each team keeps its own board.

Dependency Map

RISKS & DEPENDENCIES

A shared RAID log and dependency map, reviewed every week.

RAID Log · Dependency Map

REPORTING

A one-page outcome status report and a forecast range.

Outcome Status Report · Release Forecast

DECISIONS & GOVERNANCE

A decision log, a shared Definition of Done and clear decision rights.

RACI & Decision Log · Delegation Board

3 Programme — LEVEL 3

50+ people · many teams

120 people: 7,140 links

PLANNING

Outcomes set at the top; big-room planning for each group of teams.

OKRs · Portfolio Kanban

ROLES

Programme and portfolio leads, an RTE per group of teams, architecture and product leads.

Team Topology Design

EVENTS

Add portfolio reviews, and inspect & adapt across the whole programme.

Events & Cadences · Value Metrics

TRACKING WORK

A portfolio board of initiatives, with work in progress limited at the top.

Portfolio Kanban & Investment Mix

RISKS & DEPENDENCIES

Managed across groups of teams, with an owner at each level.

RAID Log · Value Stream Map

REPORTING

Outcome and value measures for leaders, rolled up from the same data.

Value Metrics · Outcome Status Report

DECISIONS & GOVERNANCE

Light governance: evidence from working software, risk-based approval, delegated decisions.

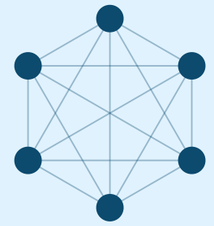
SDLC at a Glance · Delegation Board · ADKAR

4 Turn the Dial Up If... — SIZE ISN'T EVERYTHING

- [ ] High risk, safety or regulation
- [ ] Many dependencies on others
- [ ] A fixed date or contract
- [ ] Many stakeholders or senior visibility
- [ ] People across sites or time zones
- [ ] New team, domain or technology
- [ ] Long duration (many months)

Two or more ticked? Borrow the next level's practices for those areas only.

5 Coordination Grows Fast — LINKS = N × (N − 1) / 2



6 people: 15 links

4 people	**6 links**
12 people	**66 links**
40 people	**780 links**
120 people	**7,140 links**

6 Signs It's the Wrong Size

TOO LITTLE

- Surprises arrive late
- Teams block each other
- The same questions, again
- No one knows the plan

TOO MUCH

- Meetings about meetings
- Reports no one reads
- Decisions wait for sign-off
- Process for its own sake

Add structure when it solves a problem you have; remove it when it doesn't.

"What's the least structure that would keep this project safe?"

"Which part of our process could we drop without anyone missing it?"

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